

different syntax and minor differences. It's a potential game-changer and something you really should pay attention to.

Python is very easy to learn. Whether you are new to programming or a seasoned C++ coder, you can get into Python very quickly. The syntax is deliberately very easy to read. If you know nothing about Python and are shown a bit of code, right away you will see what it does. That's not true for most programming languages.

Python is, to a large extent, purpose-built for finance. There are tools available which are designed by hedge fund quants and made available to everyone for free. Tasks which would take a lot of programming in a C style language can often be done in a single line of code. Having programmed in many different languages for the past 30 years, I have never seen a language where you can get things done as quickly and easily as in Python.

In the past few years, Python has emerged as the quant's language of choice. This has resulted in a substantial community and a large amount of open source tools. For people working in finance, the quant community are surprisingly open to sharing stuff.

There are some clear issues with Python, of course. Given that most people using Python at the moment are hard-core quants, documentation tends to assume that you already know everything and there is a clear aversion to anything user-friendly. For someone entering this space, the first barrier to overcome is what at times look like a certain techno arrogance.

Daunting as it may seem when you first get started, learning Python really isn't all that hard and the payoff is high. But, of course, Python alone doesn't just do your backtesting for you. That gives you two options. You can construct your own backtester in Python, if you're proficient enough in programming, or you can pick a suitable backtesting package for Python and adapt it to your needs. The latter is far easier, and I would very much suggest that you use a little Python library called Zipline.

There is a long and colourful story behind Zipline, though most of it is no longer important. The company which built it made it available, free, and open source, before going under some years later. While some assumed that the demise of Quantopian, the company which build Zipline, would be the end of that backtesting library, it was rather the opposite. As Quantopian died, the open source community took over Zipline and its development and maintenance got a significant boost.

One of several reasons why Zipline is great tool for futures traders is that it can realistically trade individual contracts. Most backtesters simply use calculated continuations for testing, which has all kinds of realism issues.